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- LIS House minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/H

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[00:09:35] House will come to order. The House will be at ease.

[00:09:40] House will come to order.

[00:24:09] Mr. Clerk. Ms. Speaker, continuing with today's business, five after four, Virginia House of Delegates supplemental calendar number one for this 2026 session, first day. The supplemental calendar has been distributed. It's available online, so everyone has it.

[00:24:27] The first order of business on page one of the printed version, if you're following along that way. First category, resolutions, regular calendar. Resolutions regular, beginning with House Joint Resolution 1, H.J. 1, proposing an amendment to the Constitution of Virginia by adding in Article 1, a section number 11A, relating to fundamental right to reproductive freedom.

[00:24:48] This H.J.R. 1 was reported from the Committee on Privileges and Elections. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Speaking to the resolution. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, HG1 is a constitutional amendment, amending Section 1 of the Virginia Bill of Rights, which provides for a fundamental right to reproductive freedom.

[00:25:09] This amendment protects the rights of individuals to carry out decisions relating to their own prenatal care, contraception, abortion care, miscarriage management, and fertility care. Mr. Speaker, this

provides for the full spectrum of reproductive health care from birth control to fertility treatment.

[00:25:32] I hope it is a pleasure of the House to adopt the resolution. The delegate from Warren, Delegate Oates. Mr. Speaker, I rise to speak to the amendment.

[00:25:48] The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise today with a heavy heart to speak on an issue that touches the deepest part of my soul, the sacred value of life. Many new faces are here today, so let me share my story.

[00:26:05] I was a 16-year-old mom who chose life. My world is infinitely richer because of it. My son is a greatest blessing, a living testament to the miracle of human life. This debate isn't new.

[00:26:23] Let me be crystal clear about what H.J. 1 truly means and what it fails to protect. Supporters claim it merely safeguards existing law. The language is vague, broad, and elastic. As constitutional lawyers testified in committee, not just activists.

[00:26:41] It sets no firm limits, no clear standards, resolving nothing while inviting endless litigation. Once enshrined in our Constitution, these life-and-death questions won't be decided by Virginians, but by judges. That's a heartbreaking shift of power, robbing us of our voice on the most profound of moral issues.

[00:27:05] Worse still, H.J. 1 opens the door to abortions on fully viable babies. Precious children who could survive outside the womb with beating hearts. Tiny fingers and faces that we have all seen vividly on ultrasounds.

[00:27:22] Our state's amendments include explicit post-viability protections and ours does not. This is an abstract. It's about real moms, real pregnancies, and the innocent lives that we must fiercely defend.

[00:27:40] Abortion is legal today in Virginia. No Republican rollback has passed. No restrictions enacted. No bans loom. It's secure until Democrats change it themselves. The amendment won't override Congress or the Supreme Court. It won't shield us from national shifts. Instead, it recklessly alters our Constitution for a problem that may never arise. As a Commonwealth, we must cherish and protect all life, especially the most vulnerable, the unborn, who deserve our unwavering compassion and safeguard. Mr. Speaker,

[00:28:19] Virginians deserve to know that this amendment will allow the termination of a precious baby on its birthday. It eliminates parents from the process. This year, we're going to celebrate our founding, our 250th birthday, and our founding principles enshrine the inalienable rights of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

[00:28:46] This amendment threatens the first of these of the most defenseless among us, Betraying the trust we owe our people and the innocent. I pray these truths stir every conscience before we vote. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:29:06] Delegate from Bedford, Delegate Griffin. Mr. Speaker, I rise to speak to the amendment. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:29:23] As we approach another expansion of the killing of unborn babies, my message is simple. We must vote no on this. We must stand up for those who cannot protect themselves. Every single human baby has a unique DNA.

[00:29:43] A human baby is not wholly his father. She's not wholly her mother. She's unique. There's no one like her ever before. And we have a responsibility as a legislature to stand up and to defend her.

[00:30:05] We're going to hear tons of speeches over the next 60 days where people get up and they say, I'm speaking for those who can't speak for themselves. This is literally the situation where you have the opportunity to stand for those who cannot stand for themselves. You have the opportunity to speak for those who cannot speak for themselves.

[00:30:26] I want to be on the right side of history. I want to stand for those who need us today. This constitutional amendment broadens the killing of unborn babies beyond anything that we have ever seen in Virginia.

[00:30:43] It's going to expand surgical, D&E, Z&C abortions. do y'all know what they do they take sharp weapons into the womb of the mother and they slice up human babies while they are still alive and then they use vacuums to suck the body parts out of the mother's womb it is incumbent upon us as leaders to create a culture of life to lead and not to

[00:31:15] follow we cannot continue to enable this onslaught we cannot allow these babies to be killed we can't allow these mothers to be harmed by this procedure. Evil triumphs when good people do nothing. This is our opportunity to stand in the gap. This is your opportunity to do the right thing. Speak for the voiceless today. Mr. Speaker, please vote no on this amendment. Shall the resolution be agreed

[00:31:45] to? Clerk will close the roll. Ayes, 64, nos, 34. Ayes, 64, nos, 34. The resolution is agreed to.

[00:32:07] Continuing with supplemental calendar resolutions, regular, page 2, House Joint Resolution No. 2, proposing an amendment to Section 1 of Article 2 of the Constitution of Virginia relating to qualifications of voters and the right to vote, persons not entitled to vote.

[00:32:24] This legislation also is reported from the Committee on Privileges and Elections. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Bennett Parker. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise to speak to the resolution. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. This proposed constitutional amendment provides an affirmative, fundamental right to vote for qualified voters.

[00:32:43] It also provides for the automatic restoration of political rights once a person with a felony conviction is released from incarceration and also strengthens protections for individuals with disabilities, fostering a more just and fair society. Virginia is the only state to permanently disenfranchise all individuals with felony convictions unless they individually petition the governor for rights restoration.

[00:33:06] This amendment creates a transparent, fair process that applies to everyone equally and that is not left up to the complete discretion of a single individual. Research shows that the restoration of rights benefits reentry, reduces recidivism, and makes communities safer because people feel included as part of our democracy and have a say in what happens in their communities.

[00:33:25] So this amendment is critical for all Virginians. The disenfranchisement of people with felony convictions is a relic of Virginia's Jim Crow past and was intentionally inserted into the 1902 Constitution to disenfranchise as many black voters as possible. Today, more than one in seven black Virginians is disenfranchised, which is twice the national average.

[00:33:46] Another important aspect of this amendment is that it strengthens protections for individuals with disabilities, ensuring their voting rights are lost only if a court adjudicates that the person is

incapable of understanding the act of voting. This amendment is about reintegration, redemption, and justice, and recognizes that the right to vote is fundamental for our communities and for our democracy.

[00:34:06] For these reasons, Mr. Speaker, and on behalf of the many people who have worked tirelessly for decades to create a more just and fair Virginia, I move adoption of the resolution. The delegate from Henry County, Delegate Phillips. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'd like to speak to the resolution.

[00:34:22] Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I believe in second chances. I'm glad to have been the recipient of quite a few in my life. And I support, in principle, what this resolution would like to do or try to do.

[00:34:38] There's certainly been some things that have changed in our legal system over the years. You know, now in Virginia, you can grow three marijuana plants and you can smoke it in your own house or whatever. And there are a lot of people that had major felony convictions with those types of drugs that I think should be overdone. But I would also say that what makes it difficult for me to support this is I do think that there are violent felons, murderers, people who snuff out the rights of others to ever be able to do anything again in this lifetime, who should be exempted from this legislation.

[00:35:08] Secondly, one of the things that I noted in here is that their full debt to society had not been paid. In other words, this bill allows as soon as they're released from either jail or prison that their rights are fully restored. It doesn't count restitution or them coming off parole.

[00:35:25] So in my mind, Mr. Speaker, and because of those reasons, I would have a tough time supporting this. I think their full societal debt should be paid before they're able to do that. But thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Prince William, Delegate Mundin King.

[00:35:47] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Speaking to the resolution. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, we heard a lot about voiceless people today. But most people are not without a voice.

[00:36:04] And this gives the people the opportunity to decide if they want Jim Crow, Virginia, voting rights, Confederate, Virginia, voting rights. And we should give people that opportunity to vote.

[00:36:19] And what I won't do, Mr. Speaker, is allow people to use victims of horrible crimes as an excuse for taking away a fundamental right. And the reason why is because I've been on the other side of that courtroom.

[00:36:40] I've been the victim of a crime. I've sat with my family. And not once did I think, you know what, let's take away their right to vote. It is a relic of the past. People who commit crimes should pay their debt to society. And if that means a life sentence, guess what, Mr. Speaker? They don't vote for life. But to continue to hold the fundamental right to vote over people's head is not giving them a voice.

[00:37:11] So for those who want to give people a voice and speak for the voiceless, that's what this amendment does. Let the people speak. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Shall the resolution be agreed to? Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 65, noes 33. Ayes 65, noes 33. The resolution is agreed to. Continuing with a category of regular calendar resolutions, House Trump Resolution 3. Proposing an amendment to Section 15A of Article 1 of the Constitution

[00:37:51] of Virginia relating to marriage between two adult persons, repeal of same-sex marriage prohibition, affirmative right to marry. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sickles. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I've Talked about this downstairs a few minutes ago about the happiness amendment.

[00:38:08] This is happiness for people who want to have legal security in their family. That's all this does. This is a civil rights bill. Mr. Speaker, I just want to read it. It's really short. That marriage is one of the vital personal rights essential to the orderly pursuit of happiness.

[00:38:29] This Commonwealth and its political subdivisions shall not deny the issues of a marriage license to adult persons seeking a lawful marriage on the basis of sex, gender, or the race of such person. This Commonwealth and its political subdivisions shall recognize any lawful marriage between two adult persons and treat such marriages equally under the law, regardless of the sex, gender, or race of such persons.

[00:38:54] So it's not a zero-sum game. Your marriage is not going to be hurt by my marriage. we've had marriage equality for 11 years. We're still standing. We're probably a stronger country than we were before. We got happier people. Let's make more people happy. Let's get rid of this bad language because if the Supreme Court rules and nobody thinks anymore that this Supreme Court might not overturn Obergefell, that, you know, I thought at first maybe they would never do that, but I read the newspapers. So we really need this. We do really need this. We can't go back

[00:39:32] to what we had. Read the language that's there. I've read the new language. The language that's there is really horrible. No domestic partnership, no civil union, nothing that looks like a marriage or reflects a marriage. We can't go back to that, Mr. Speaker. We have gone far beyond that. Let's give the voters a chance to get rid of this once and for all, 20 years after it was put in our Constitution. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I urge everyone to support this resolution.

[00:40:01] The delegate from Buckingham, Delegate Garrett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I was reviewing the rules of the House, and I am not sure if I can do this, but I would ask if the patron would yield for a question. You can speak to the motion. Okay, let me speak to the motion. He can yield. You're right. He can yield. Yeah, and these aren't even hostile questions.

[00:40:16] Okay. This time? I know. They're going to be hostile. Will the delegate yield? I know the gentleman from Buckingham is a progressive. I think the delegate will yield. So, oh, they weren't hostile questions, y'all.

[00:40:34] No, it's a three-part question. I'm not trying to trip you or anything. We did this last year. I want to understand, it is not the, and I understand textualism versus purposivism, but it's not the intent of the patron that this, that refusal of an officiant or a clergy member to perform a ceremony that violated their conscience could be used to disallow them from performing ceremonies. That's not your intent? Not my intent and not permitted.

[00:41:01] The delegate from Fairfax County, I know you haven't left yet, I'm still the speaker. The delegate from Fairfax County, you have the floor. I yield. The delegate from Fairfax, is that your intent?

[00:41:17] You have this question. I agree with the gentleman that it's not intended to do that. And Mr. Speaker? Will the delegate yield for another question? Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Y'all are going to get used to this. I love you, man. Will the delegate yield? Second question. Is it your understanding that this amendment cannot be used to force an officiant to officiate a ceremony against their conscience?

[00:41:39] Delegate from Fairfax. Absolutely not. And finally, is it your intent for this amendment to be able to be used in any event, speaking to the amendment, Mr. Speaker? The delegate has the floor. I voted in favor of this last year, and then I went to church on Sunday, and my pastor said why.

[00:41:58] And I told him, and I'm going to vote in favor of it again this year, right? I know two things to a metaphysical certainty. There is a God, and I am not him. And it's my responsibility to do the best I can being me, but it's not my responsibility to judge other people, consistent with their values or my own.

[00:42:15] But I'm terrified by the idea that this legislation might be used to force an officiant, whether Muslim or Catholic or Southern Baptist, to perform a ceremony that violates their conscience. The First Amendment of the Constitution, the Establishment Clause, Speaker, says that Congress's legislative body shall make no laws establishing a religion, everybody knows that, nor prohibiting the free practice thereof.

[00:42:38] Right? So when the Family Foundation came to me when I was in another chamber a long time ago and said, where are you on this? I said, why is the state even involved? given that Unitarian Universalists might have a different idea than Calvary Chapel. So I do believe my Bible. But I will vote in favor allowing this to go to a referendum of the people of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:42:57] And if one day this amendment is used to force people who have differences in opinions from any of us to do something that violates their conscience, then we did it wrong. And that's why I stand to address this bill, Mr. Speaker. I respect each and every one of you, whether we agree or disagree.

[00:43:14] I may vote very differently in the referendum than I vote on whether we should have the referendum. But real tyranny comes when we force people to do things that violate their own conscience, consistent with the establishment of free religion in this Constitutional Republic. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:43:31] Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker. Speaking to the bill. Speaking to the resolution. The delegate has the floor again. I just want to clarify that this resolution does not force anybody to do anything.

[00:43:47] It just allows people to pursue happiness as the Constitution and the Declaration of Independence called for. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price. Saving us time, speaking to the resolution instead of asking a question.

[00:44:07] Thank you. If I had time to ask questions, I would ask the gentleman across the aisle if he had read line 24, because then I would be able to go tell my pastor that he is not a commonwealth or a political subdivision. And that is the language of this amendment.

[00:44:22] Furthermore, I would be able to tell my pastor if he had asked me such that Article 1 and Section 16 is still standing in Virginia's Constitution. And so I would then ask any of us that want to speak on this floor to give up the fear tactics and let the people be happy. I urge us to support this joint resolution.

[00:44:41] Shall the resolution be agreed to? Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 67, noes 31.

[00:44:59] Ayes 67, noes 31. The resolution is agreed to. And, Mr. Speaker, over on page 3 of the pen and calendar, finally, we come to House Joint Resolution 4, H.J.R. 4, proposing an amendment to Section 6 of Article 2 of the Constitution of Virginia and proposing an amendment to the Constitution of Virginia by adding in the schedule a Section 6 relating to apportionment, congressional districts, limited authority of the General Assembly to modify legislation reporting on privileges and elections.

[00:45:28] The delegate from Henrico, Delegate Willett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, speaking to the resolution. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. HCR 4 creates a narrow temporary exception, allowing the Virginia General Assembly to modify one or more congressional districts between

the regular 10-year decennial reapportionments if another U.S. state has redrawn its congressional districts mid-decade for reasons other than completing the decennial that was started or in response to a court order.

[00:46:00] Mr. Speaker, very briefly, just to summarize what this resolution does and does not do. First of all, what it does, this keeps Virginia's options open. This would enable us to preserve flexibility. If the people approve it and then we implement it, we could make redistricting decisions.

[00:46:18] But there's no mandate here to do so. This is temporary. As I should emphasize, this measure will expire in 2030 and we'll be back to the regular 10-year cycle for redistricting. And most significantly, this allows the voters to decide how we do redistricting.

[00:46:35] They will vote if this is approved. They will vote in a referendum to approve or not approve what is proposed. Also, briefly, what this amendment does not do, it does not eliminate the Virginia Redistricting Commission. They will continue to do their job every 10 years.

[00:46:53] It does not expand our authority to change state legislative districts. We are not drawing our own lines. This only affects the congressional districts, and it does not change any of our existing lines, legislative lines. It just creates a process to consider doing so or consider making a change in extraordinary circumstances.

[00:47:15] Mr. Speaker, thank you, and I hope it will be the will of this body to approve this resolution. The delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Ladies and gentlemen of the House, most of you know I've been here quite a while, And thankful to my constituents back home in the 45th district, used to be the first district, the most farther, for those of you all who are new, I live in the most farther western corner of Virginia.

[00:47:40] But, you know, I've been here quite a while, and I can say, unless it's been court order, we've never done this. We've never, ever redrawn lines or attempted to redraw lines mid-session. We had an opportunity one time when my party was in power, when the Senate called an individual gone and decided that they were going to redistrict midterm and redistrict the Senate.

[00:48:06] But, Mr. Speaker, we didn't do that. Bill Howe, then Speaker Howe, said that's wrong. That's not the Virginia way. That's not the way we do things here in the Commonwealth of Virginia. And that's the difference here. We shouldn't care about what other states are doing.

[00:48:23] We should care about what Virginia is doing, what message we're sending to our constituents. Two-thirds of the individuals across this state adopted this amendment just a few years ago, and now we're trying to throw it out because of things going on in other states, other states that do not have this constitutional amendment, other states that don't have the bipartisanship that we had when we passed this amendment.

[00:48:51] So, I mean, and that's what I'm saying. You know, we were willing to live by that rule when our party was in charge, even if it cost us, even if it cost us control of one chamber. And, ladies and gentlemen, all I'm asking is, is it worth it? Is it worth it to throw out the Virginia way here just because of what's going on in other states, just because of what's going on in D.C.?

[00:49:15] We've got a state to govern. We need to be governing our state, talking about issues that affect our state, like affordability, something that we've all been talking about. That's what we need to do, not be

focusing on hyper-partisan issues such as this.

[00:49:31] Ladies and gentlemen, I hope that you will come to your census and say, this is not the Virginia way. Come to your census like Indiana did. This is not the way we need to be going. We need to redraw the lines when we redraw the lines after the census is done.

[00:49:47] So I appreciate it. Think about it. Just think what you're doing. We're the oldest democracy in the Western Hemisphere, the oldest democracy. We didn't always get it right. We've not always got it right.

[00:50:02] But I think we got it right when we did the bipartisan redistricting. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Patrick County, Delegate Williams.

[00:50:20] Mr. Speaker, I rise to speak to the resolution. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I'd ask if the patron would yield for a question. Will the patron yield? I yield, Mr. Speaker. The patron will yield. In 2020, nearly two-thirds of Virginia told us they wanted politics out of our map-making.

[00:50:39] Why would we reverse course now, even under what is alleged to be a carve-out for extraordinary emergencies? Mr. Speaker, I'm responding to the question in front of the delegate.

[00:50:56] No one woke up in October and said, gosh, I really feel like admitting the Constitution today. Our hand was forced. Our hand was forced here by the extraordinary actions coming from Washington by a president who contacted not one, not two, but multiple states and directed them to redistrict and change the election picture and essentially disenfranchise Virginia voters and other states that would vote Democratic.

[00:51:24] We couldn't stand for that. When a bully punches you, sometimes you have to punch back. And that's what we did. It was not our choice, but we're here. And again, as this amendment specifies, these are extraordinary circumstances. That's the only time. That's the only time this can be done.

[00:51:40] Thank you. Mr. Speaker, follow-up question. Will the delegate yield? I yield. Who determines what extraordinary emergencies details? Mr. Speaker, responding to the question, that's actually in the circumstances or when a state has taken action, not in the decennial, either if it's not completing a decennial redistricting or if it's not in response to court order, if they change the lines and the state does that, that gives us the option to look at redistricting.

[00:52:15] And, again, nothing, nothing in this amendment mandates that there be a change. It's just there would be the option to look at that. And, of course, if this is passed, if the voters approve it, there would, of course, be implementing law to dictate that process. Thank you.

[00:52:31] Mr. Speaker, speaking to the resolution. Delegate to the floor. Like I said, in 2020, nearly two-thirds of Virginians told us that they wanted politics out of our map making. Two-thirds. When have we ever agreed on something at a two-thirds percentage?

[00:52:51] And we agreed to do an independent commission so that these maps could be drawn by nonpartisan individuals working together to make our maps better, more cohesive, and lacking the gerrymandering that we've been seeing for years.

[00:53:10] But the problem with this effort, this rush to change our Constitution, is how blatantly obvious it is that it's a power grab. Essentially what you want to do is you want to game the system in response to other states.

[00:53:35] And the problem with that is that you're taking that redistricting out of the public's hands. When they clearly stated they wanted politics or they wanted the maps out of our hands.

[00:53:53] And now you're saying that not only do we get to pull the maps from the public, but we get to decide when the extraordinary emergency occurs so that we can trigger the provision that will allow us to draw the maps on their behalf.

[00:54:14] So you're trying to sneak this one by the citizens. You were able to rush us through special session. and now we're on the floor today one of the very first days obviously and then we're probably going to have a may referendum i mean this is just an absolute obvious attempt to as you say push back against what the other states were doing but i don't teach my kid to do something wrong or bend

[00:54:52] his principles just because he's reacting to someone who has done something wrong or bent their principles. There are other states who held firm and did not answer the call that you all are concerned about. We can do that. There's no reason for us to change anything. And I've never seen a sunset provision or a triggering provision inside of a constitution. So I would urge you to vote no on this and stick with two-thirds of Virginians who agreed with us in 2020. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:55:32] The Delegate from Buckingham, Delegate Garrett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. You're speaking to the resolution. Delegate, have the floor. I wasn't going to speak, and then I heard the word disenfranchisement. And I've got to say that I am an admirer of my colleague from Henrico.

[00:55:51] He's got ties to Farmville. I used to represent Longwood. He's got a William & Mary connection. That was the first place that a Garrett ever attended college. But this is the embodiment of disenfranchisement. What's happening here? This is disenfranchisement. We've already forced the clerk of our fine House of Delegates, who we voted unanimously reinstall to abrogate the laws of the Commonwealth by not providing notice to the clerks of the court 90 days in advance before a constitutional amendment was to be on the agenda.

[00:56:17] He couldn't comply with the law because we didn't do it timely. And we're doing this so that we can disenfranchise the 5 out of 11, which is a rough approximation of the percentage of Virginians that voted Republican in the last presidential election, so that we can push them out of the way in a power grab.

[00:56:35] And I understand the defense that they did at first. I get it. It's a wonderful defense in third grade. But a man far wiser than me once said, an eye for an eye makes the whole world blind, and I wish not to live in that world. California, Missouri, North Carolina, Ohio, Texas, Utah, South Carolina, Virginia, Washington, Florida, Maryland, Alabama, Louisiana, New York, North Dakota, have all either done this or are looking at doing at it.

[00:56:58] You know what makes Virginia different? We are the only state on the list that I named that had a constitutional amendment that passed in 99 out of 100 House of Delegates districts five short years ago. So we know how this vote's going to go.

[00:57:16] But we're treating our voters as if we think they're stupid. They told us what they wanted, and 60-some-odd people in this room are going to say, we don't care. We have a constitutional amendment that ensures nonpartisan redistricting that I didn't like any more than anybody else, but probably got it pretty close to right.

[00:57:36] And we have that because the people said overwhelmingly, literally, in 99 out of 100 House districts, this is what we want, but they did it first. If that's the argument that you wish to rise or fall upon, so be it. But the pendulum will never stop in the middle.

[00:57:53] And so the precedent is dangerous. All of those states did what they did. In Texas's case, it was ultimately court-ordered, so know all the history, not just the history that suits your argument. But none of them, like Virginia, had a constitutional amendment to prevent precisely what you plan and intend to do.

[00:58:11] The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sickles. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I just wanted to make a couple of points. Having served on the P&E Committee for 22 years, This reverence coming from the other side for nonpartisan redistricting is really a bit hard to take because every year we had nonpartisan redistricting bills killed by the other side.

[00:58:39] Every year. Ken Plum had the bill every year. We wanted nonpartisan redistricting. You know when the other side wanted to do it? When they were in the minority. And then they had uniform support, 100% support when they were in the minority, and we were maybe naive enough to go along with it, and here we are, and it didn't work.

[00:58:58] The courts drew the seats we're in now. That commission did not work like we hoped it would in having a bipartisan group of Democrats and Republicans and citizens come up with these districts.

[00:59:14] It did not work. The court drew these seats. So I don't know how much reverence we have for that. But this is an emergency. If this is not an emergency for American democracy, I don't know what is. Please vote yes.

[00:59:30] The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Simon. Mr. Speaker, speaking of the amendment. Delegates, the floor. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, I just want to clear up a couple of things we heard over on the other side.

[00:59:48] To listen to them talk, you would think, first of all, that we were doing away with the Nonpartisan Redistricting Commission. And I share other delegates from Fairfax's disdain for that, but that's not what this resolution does. That's not what this constitutional amendment does. The Nonpartisan Redistricting Commission remains in place, untouched, unaffected by this amendment.

[01:00:07] I want to be very clear about that. Nothing that we're doing today affects how we elect members of the House of Delegates or the State Senate, right? Nothing in this amendment affects any of that. So regardless of what was happening before, none of that is affected by this. And the other thing I want to say really clearly about this is, you know, keep talking about that two-thirds majority that really loved the Nonpartisan Redistricting Commission, which, by the way, remains.

[01:00:29] You're so confident that this is really unpopular, what we're doing, and that the voters really love keeping it nonpartisan. Pass this resolution. Pass this resolution, because you know what happens after this resolution? passes there's a referendum we get to go back to the voters again and they're the ones who get to decide what we do going forward right so this isn't us grabbing anything from anybody this is a resolution that empowers the people of virginia and i know it's just five short six short years ago but i suspect you guys understand that things have changed we can tell by the seating chart that things aren't the same as they were five or six years ago right the voters have had an opportunity to see what's going on and they need an opportunity to look at what's happening in

[01:01:08] Washington to look at what the president is doing, to look at the calls that he's making. And we're talking about what's plain and obvious and unabashed is the president's call to give me more seats. And why does he want more seats? Because he saw what happened here in Virginia in November. And he knows that's what's likely to happen across the country in 2026 unless they work to rig the system, right? All this is doing is saying we know that we want to hold the president accountable for his unpopular positions at the midterms. We don't want the country to rig their elections. This is one small thing that we can do here in Virginia, if the voters agree to it, to unrig the system, bring some fairness back to the process, and ensure that the people have a

[01:01:47] voice and can be heard at the national level. Mr. Speaker, members of the House, I encourage you to vote yes and pass the resolution. The delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price. Speaking to the resolution, Mr. Speaker. Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you. A lot has been said, and so I will not be long. But something really struck me, Mr. Speaker. Is it worth it? And you know who I

[01:02:20] thought about? SNAP recipients who will no longer be able to feed their families. I thought about the constituents in the 85th district who have told me that with the expiration of the health care tax credits, they will lose life-saving treatment because of our current situation.

[01:02:44] is it worth it? Is it worth it to the federal worker who got the job for upward mobility and was fired because of Doge? Residents who want to be able to safely walk the streets and not live in fear? Virginians who want their First Amendment rights back to be able to speak out against this administration without someone knocking on their door? Is it worth it? Is it worth it? My answer is yes. And that's why I'm supporting this resolution. Because as was stated,

[01:03:23] since the last vote on redistricting, what the other side of the aisle never spoke out about was when their friends in North Carolina gerrymandered a map so hard that Republicans got the 218 majority and are now the party in power. Never spoke out about that. But we are supposed to sit here and listen to their call for us to have morality. Those actions that those 218

[01:03:59] are taking impact Virginia every day, Mr. Speaker. You know this, our budget, affordability, our freedoms. And so it's time that we level the playing field. And it's time to let the voters decide the exact opposite of disenfranchisement, putting a ballot in their hand to say,

[01:04:23] Let you decide. Do you want this new dysfunctional norm since you voted last time? Or do you want to fight back? That is the epitome of what it is we stand for in this here, our oldest democracy that we on this side of the aisle are trying to save.

[01:04:46] So it is with exuberant support that I give this joint resolution, and I ask everyone in this chamber to let the voters decide. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Shall the resolution be agreed to?

[01:05:18] Clerk will close the roll. Ayes, 62.

[01:05:33] Nos, 33. Abstentions, 1. Ayes, 62. Nos, 33. Abstentions, 1. The resolution is agreed to. Ms. Speaker, that completes work on supplemental calendar number 1. I'm pleased to work at the House today, which I'm aware of. Does the clerk have any announcements?

[01:05:52] Ms. Speaker, not at this time after the end of the joint assembly. Later, I'll look at the calendar for tomorrow, but I have nothing at this time. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr.

Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House stand in recess until 6.30 p.m., and may I speak to that motion?

[01:06:11] Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, we are friends of the House. We are going to be in recess. We ask that people get here before 6:30. That's when the gavel will fall, at 6:30, so 15 minutes before, 10 minutes before you could be in the chamber and headed to your seats would be appreciated.

[01:06:30] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. DELEGATE FROM ALEXANDRIA: Delegate hearing moves that the House stand in recess until 6:30 p.m. As many in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands in recess until 6:30 p.m.